



For such a little person, your **amazing new baby** requires a lot of taking care of. If this is your first time taking care of a newborn, you may feel you lack the full qualifications for the job. Rest assured that, while it's very natural for new parents to feel a little nervous, your **confidence will grow** in the coming days and weeks.

Taking care of your baby

On-the-job training

So much of parenting is about learning on the job, and you will find that your baby is naturally forgiving of any initial awkwardness. What he needs from the outset is your love, attention, and reassurance that you are there to meet his needs. The rest of your parenting skills will soon fall into place: where those early cries perplexed, before long you will be able to decipher what it is your baby is asking for, and from those first tentative holds, you'll become adept at handling and holding your baby just the way he likes while you wash, dress, and soothe him.

Taking care of your baby every day

An important part of taking care of your baby is making sure he is kept clean and comfortable and he is safe in his environment. From preventing diaper rash to ensuring good sleep hygiene—making sure his sleep environment is safe and conducive to rest—the everyday care you give your baby helps him feel content. Many of the practices you put in place in these early days will instill good habits for life. In addition to your baby's everyday practical care,

he also needs stimulation and interaction with you and his environment. At first, this may be as simple as making eye contact, copying facial expressions, and exchanging smiles. Then, increasingly, play and stimulation will involve activities, toys, and exploring other environments. All the time you spend together, both in play and with simple caring tasks, helps strengthen your bond.

Young babies are vulnerable to infection, so avoiding contact with germs is a good idea. However, your baby will inevitably be unwell at some point. Knowing what signs indicate that your baby is sick, and when to seek medical help, can reassure you that you will give your baby the care he needs.

Taking care of you

These early weeks and months taking care of your little one are amazing and all consuming. Getting the right amount of rest, being mutually supportive with your partner about your baby's care, and paying attention to your diet and lifestyle will ensure you have the energy and resources needed to give your baby your very best care.